

1785



The power loom transformed the textile industry.

IN 1784, EDMUND CARTWRIGHT (1743–1823), an English clergyman, paid a visit to a cotton-spinning mill established by Richard Arkwright (see 1771). What he saw inspired him to invent similar machines to weave textiles. By 1785 he had patented his first **power loom**. Cartwright's loom became an integral part of the textile industry in Britain. The design was later improved by the American businessman **Francis Cabot Lowell**, who had seen the looms in operation on a visit to Britain, and its use was widespread on both sides of the Atlantic after 1820.

In Burma, the Konbaung dynasty's **King Bodawpaya** (1745–1819) had captured the coastal kingdom of Arakan the previous year. Bolstered by this victory, he decided to move to the east and invade the kingdom of Siam (Thailand), but was defeated.

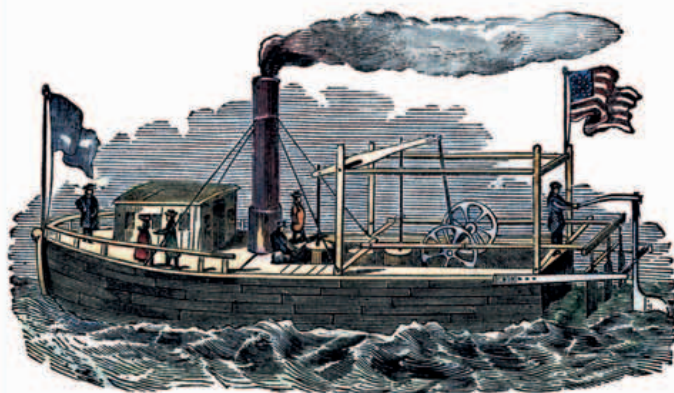


Round-the-world expedition
Jean-François de Galaup, the comte de Lapérouse, was sent by Louis XVI on an expedition to map out the uncharted waters of the Pacific.

1786



Frederick II of Prussia was feared and admired throughout Europe for his military prowess.



THE US WAS EXPERIENCING AN ERA OF TECHNOLOGICAL innovation. In Philadelphia, Pennsylvania, inventor **John Fitch** (1743–1798) had set up the Steamboat Company with the aim of designing a steam-powered boat. Fitch found success ahead of his rivals in August 1787 when the **Perseverance** successfully sailed on the Delaware River. By 1790, a fledgling steamer service was running between Philadelphia and Trenton, New Jersey, but Fitch struggled as he had trouble attracting investors. It would take the more advanced boat designs and superior business acumen of **Robert Fulton** (1765–1815) before steamboat travel became a viable commercial enterprise.

First steamboat

John Fitch managed to take steam-engine technology and apply it to boats. However, commercial success was some way off.

Shipping still had its perils and **pirate** raids were common. US merchants wishing to trade in the Mediterranean markets risked attack and the **Barbary corsairs** were particularly feared. On July 23, the US signed a treaty with Morocco which assured safe passage for US ships in exchange for trading on equal terms.

In Europe, Prussia mourned the death of **Frederick II**. He had turned **Prussia** into a formidable power, and reshaped Europe's political balance.

“AN EDUCATED PEOPLE CAN BE EASILY GOVERNED.”

Attributed to Frederick II, king of Prussia

1787



This 19th-century engraving depicts the coastal settlement of Sierra Leone, West Africa.

AFTER THE RULING IN THE SOMERSETT CASE (see 1772), which established that slaves who arrived in Britain were free, many slaves were abandoned by their masters and the “**black poor**” of London were left with no means of support. Abolitionist Granville Sharp (1735–1813) arranged for a free settlement to be established in **Sierra Leone**, West Africa. The ship **Nautilus** returned some 400 former slaves to Africa. These initial settlers were later joined by slaves from **Nova Scotia**, Canada, who had fought for the British in the American Revolutionary War. At the same time, West Africa was still rife with other European slavers.

In the US, there was a growing call for a stronger central government and, from May to September, the **Constitutional Convention** met, ostensibly in order to amend the Articles of Confederation (see 1781). But



Slave settlement

Sierra Leone is located on the west coast of Africa. Previously a trading post for slavery it became a place of settlement for freed slaves.

instead, the delegates drew up a new system of government. They created a **bicameral legislature** in which all states would be equally represented in the Senate and proportionally based on population in the House of Representatives.

In Russia, designs on Ottoman territory led to the **Russo-Turkish War**, lasting until 1792.

US CONSTITUTION



The US Constitution is the oldest written constitution in the world still in use. It was adopted on September 17, 1787 and has been amended 27 times to deal with issues such as freedom of speech. George Washington (left) led the Constitutional Convention and became the first US president in 1789. During his presidency, the first ten amendments, known as the Bill of Rights, were ratified.

Edmund Cartwright revolutionizes weaving with invention of the power loom

Lapérouse sets off on his voyage to map the Pacific

Burma's King Bodawpaya (1745–1819) invades Siam, triggering Siamese-Burmese War (to 1792)

Ottoman authority reasserted over Egypt

August 11 Marquess Cornwallis becomes Governor-General of Bengal (to 1793)

August 11 Francis Light takes control of Penang on Malay coast for British East India Company

August 17 Frederick II, king of Prussia dies

Sierra Leone established for freed slaves from Britain and its colonies

Ottoman War with Russia and Austria (to 1792) over Russia's annexation of the Crimean, and Turkish attempts to provoke a Tatar revolt

May 13 "First Fleet" of settlers, including 778 convicts, leaves Britain for New South Wales

August 22 American inventor John Fitch (1743–98) makes successful trial run of steamboat on Delaware River

British Society for the Abolition of the Slave Trade established